

LO3

Describe the importance of interviews

© Stockbyte/Thinkstock



“

People like to hire those who show persistent optimism...

—Brandon Toropov

”

To be successful in job interviews, one must understand the three phases, which require considerable amount of preparation on the part of an interviewee. This chapter throws light on the three major phases, viz. phase 1-before the interview, phase 2-during the interview and phase 3-after the interview. There are certain skills that define these three phases.

Phase I: Before the Interview

You need to be very enthusiastic about the interview. Interview should be regarded as an opportunity rather than a threat. It is a win-win situation because firstly you get a chance to share your knowledge and secondly even if you don't get a job, you get a platform to express and project your skills to comparative strangers. Thus it gives you experience. You tend to work in the direction of improving your skills and eventually it turns out to be a learning experience.

Stay enthusiastic, stay focussed and express effectively—is the success mantra for job interview.

There are several preparatory steps which are helpful in ensuring your success in job interview. They are discussed as under.

a. Know thyself

Socrates has not uttered this phrase “know thyself” without any context. Interviews give an opportunity to introspect and assess your skills. The process of knowing your skills prepares you not only for the interview but also for the job. But how should one assess himself/herself? You must begin by evaluating your skills, strengths, weakness, attitudes, likes, dislikes, abilities, values, goals, aspirations, etc. This self-evaluation will help you to work on your weaknesses, and also make you understand the extent of improvement required in an area. Such kind of assessment makes you ready for those interviews, where the topic is “you”. It is important to highlight your strengths and downplay your weaknesses. Make a list of the skills, strengths/weaknesses and anticipate questions based on behaviour. Nearly 70% of the organisations nowadays use behaviour based interviews. “Tell me something about yourself” or “Why should we hire you” are commonly asked behaviour based questions. Though these questions appear simple yet they are subtle and tricky. A candidate who prepares himself/herself on his/her strengths and weaknesses feels comfortable answering behaviour based questions.

b. Identify your skills

These may include your talents, interests, hobbies, and organisational skills such as leadership skills, team skills, time management skills or communication skills. You need to list out your contributions to any clubs,

committees, or societies that you are affiliated to. Skills also include your soft skills which include your basic mannerisms and usages of correct and courteous words and phrases and appropriate non-verbal cues. It is very important to practise soft skills during the interview.

c. Research the company

Why is it important to know about the company in which you plan to work? Knowing about the company before the interview enhances your confidence and makes you feel comfortable in front of interviewers. A good research and analysis of the company helps you anticipate questions and prepare the answers keeping in mind the concerns and needs of the company. Thus it gives you chance to align your skills with the requirement of the company. Moreover, once you have researched the company, the interviewers no longer remain strangers to you and facing people you know, even you know them a bit, reduces anxiety and improves your confidence level.

Some of the useful research tools include:

- ♦ Website, HR/PR division
- ♦ Social media
- ♦ CD-TOMs
- ♦ Journals, magazines, newspapers
- ♦ Network of contacts and friends

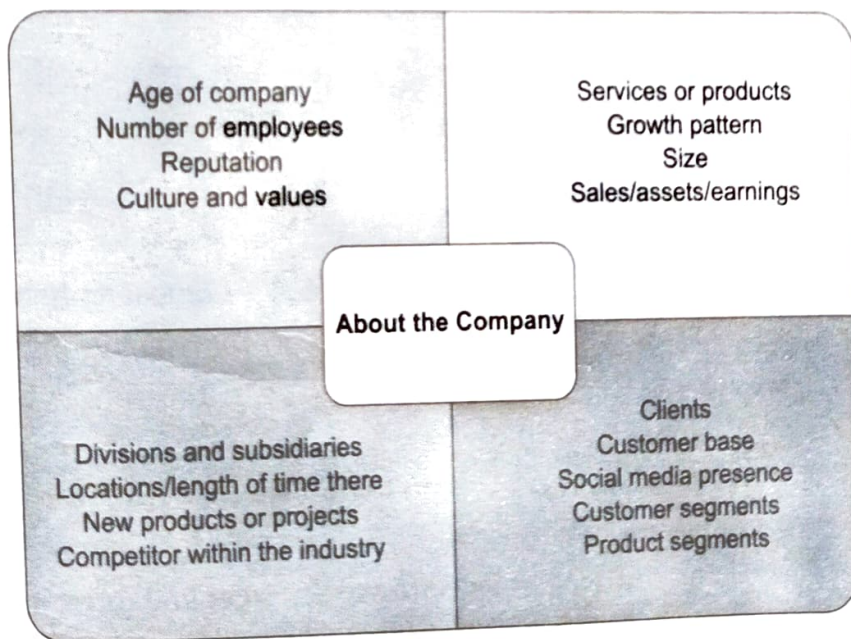


FIGURE 6.3 What you Need to Know about the Company

d. Acknowledge your nervousness

“

Make all those butterflies in your stomach to fly in one direction.

”

The challenge is to convert nervousness into nervous energy which is the basis of much needed enthusiasm. Advance preparation, organisation of thoughts and ideas, anticipation of questions and preparation of their answers, help reduce nervousness. One should also practise worst possible questions that could be asked. Dress rehearsals prepare you mentally for the interview scenario and make you feel relaxed and comfortable.

Apart from these, you need to take deep breaths and focus on relaxing.

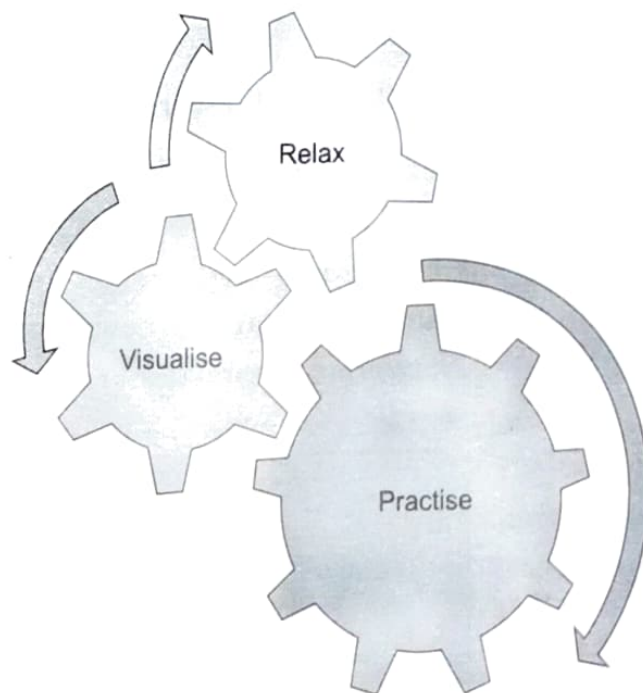


FIGURE 6.4 Combating Nervousness

e. Develop positive attitude

“

Positive attitude separates winners from losers.

”

You need to be enthusiastic, eager and interested. Good eye contact, smile and erect-but-lean forward sitting posture are some of the ways; one can practice to project the right attitude. Candidate's preparedness, open mindedness and willingness to contribute are major parameters to gauge his/her positive attitude.

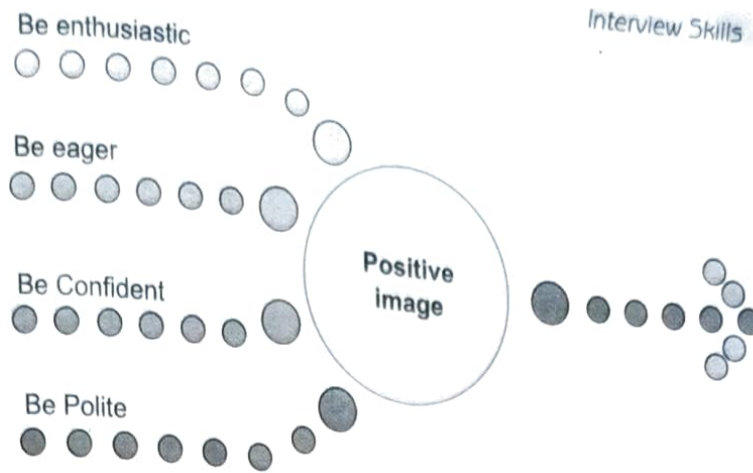


FIGURE 6.5 Positive Image

f. Dress appropriately

If you cannot dress seriously, interviewers will not take you seriously. Much before they hear you, they see you. Hence make a good first impression. Clothing is nowadays no longer limited to fulfilling one's basic needs. It communicates what you feel about yourself and what image you want others to have about you. Some basic requirements for appearance include:

- ♦ Well-groomed and clean.
- ♦ Nicely styled hair.
- ♦ Natural, clean looking face/makeup.
- ♦ Clean fingernails.
- ♦ No clunky jewellery.
- ♦ Clean and ironed clothes.
- ♦ No strong perfumes or colognes.

TABLE 6.2 Tips for dressing

MEN	WOMEN
Business suits in dark colours (blues, greys, browns) and shirt (white, cream, sky blue)	Suit in soothing colours
Trousers, fullsleeve shirts, tie, belt and formal shoes	Trousers and full shirt
Polished shoes	Straight dress with jacket
Socks-appropriate colour and length	Polished, low heeled shoes
	Minimal accessories
	No tight fitting or revealing dress

Phase II: During the Interview

Now is the time when you are face to face with the interviewers. Keep in mind that you have come a long way waiting for this opportune moment, hence do not lose focus and stay calm. With the right attitude, and presence of mind, you can either make it or break it. It is therefore imperative to keep following pointers in mind during this period.

- (a) **Practice good manners and soft skills:** It starts with reaching the venue on time. Treat the receptionist and fellow interviewees with respect. Use Mr or Ms unless they ask you to use first name. Don't sit until you are invited to do so.
- (b) **Carry complete portfolio:** Your portfolio should include several copies of resumes, new notepad and a nice pen. Use a briefcase or a leather folder for maintaining your portfolio. Carry names, addresses, phone numbers of references.
- (c) **Use powerful words:** Positive attitude is reflected not only through the effective use of nonverbal cues but also by the rightful use of powerful positive words. It is always better to use positive statements rather than using negative statements. It is like saying what you can do and what you have done instead of suggesting what you cannot do and what you have not done. It is a matter of seeing the positive or the bright side of the things.

■ **TABLE 6.3** Words to use and to avoid

USE POSITIVE WORDS	AVOID EXTREME WORDS
Accomplish, Success, Achieve, Accommodate, Attain, Challenge, Enhance, Talent, Passionate, Energy, Enthusistic, Excellence, Fulfil, Goal, Opportunity, Perform, Passion, Satisfy, Strike	Always, Extremely, Never, No one, Everyone, Entire, Completely

- (d) **Use Effective nonverbal cues:** Your non-verbal cues should synchronise with your verbal portion. Merely usage of positive words would not suffice. Effective and appropriate nonverbal cues would strengthen your overall communication. As stated earlier, people see you first, before they hear you, hence use of nonverbal communication begins right from your appearance. Right posture is a sign of right attitude. Walking with confidence shows high spirits and enthusiasm. Next is the use of haptics. Greet your interviewers with a firm handshake. Stand up to meet people. Practise good eye contact and maintain your eye contact with the question asker, do not look here and there. Your facial expressions should also be positive. Wear a smile to show enthusiasm and eagerness. Use open gestures, do not cross arms and always nod while listening to the questions. Do not play with the pen or fiddle with the button of your jacket. Speak clearly and distinctly. Do not slur, chop or truncate sounds or words or sentences. Use clear and crisp articulation. Modulate your voice with the right tone and the right pitch. Speak at a pace which can be understood by all. If offered tea-snacks by the interviewers, you must practise your dining etiquettes. Needless to say that one must use courteous words as far as possible. "Please", "thank you", etc., bring about courtesy in one's attitude; hence it is essential to remember these words.
- (e) **Create 60-second Byte About Yourself:** If the interview starts with the commonly asked, "Tell me something about yourself" question, create a very organised clear and lucid 60 second answer. You may include some of the following points:
- ♦ Geographic region
 - ♦ Reason for choosing major
 - ♦ Educational background
 - ♦ Two to three strengths related to the position
 - ♦ Specific expertise and accomplishments
 - ♦ How you can contribute to the company
 - ♦ Career goals, etc.

Since a lot of organisations prefer behaviour based interviews, prior preparation of questions based on behaviour will make the interviewee comfortable and at ease.

- (f) **Answer the Questions with a STAR Approach:** STAR approach essentially helps in organising the content of the answers in a more systematic and logical way. It provides a general framework in which the contents of the answer can be placed to make the most meaningful structure. It is broken down as given in Figure 6.6:

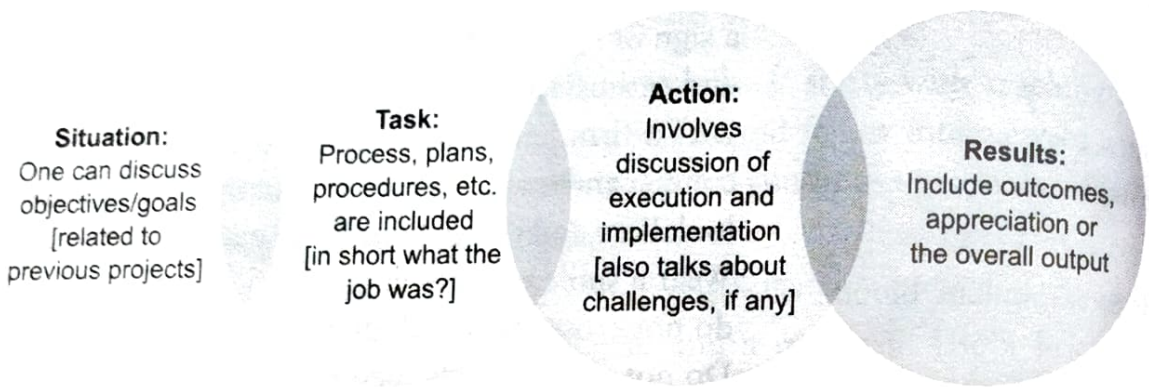


FIGURE 6.6 *Star Approach*

Star approach provides an outline which prevents you from unnecessary rambling and repeating your points. It helps you answer concisely by providing enough information. It allows the interviewer to see you as a problem solver and decision maker.

- (g) **Listen carefully:** It is important to pay full attention to the interviewers and to understand the questions completely. Listening attentively also shows your readiness and eagerness to understand and respond. If you do not follow the question, seek clarification. It is okay to ask if you can take few seconds to think about your answer. Listening is one of the most important skills in communication and is much sought out by the organisations; hence listen carefully-stay connected-stay focussed.

After the Interview

Do not become complacent after the interview is over. “It’s finally over” should not cross your mind, instead this is the perfect time and the best opportunity you have to assess yourself. However, self-assessment should be objective; neither become hypercritical of your capabilities nor get involved in overestimating your skills. You may begin by:

- (a) **Evaluating yourself:** The first question that needs to be addressed here is “How did I do overall”. Objectively assess answers and responses that you gave to the interviewers. Try to gauge if anything that you could have added or deleted from your answers. At the

same time, note down all the comments (if any) that you received from the interviewers. Next, list out your strengths as this will help you in your future endeavours too. Lastly, ask candidly “What needs improvement”. Prepare a list of areas/skills that you may need to consider and work upon to bridge the gap between your strengths and weaknesses.

- (b) **Developing a follow-up chart:** It is important to track your status with respect to the prospective job for which you appeared in the interview. It is suggested that a “thank you mail” should be sent to the interviewers. There is no harm in asking for the updates on the status of the selection process.

TABLE 6.4 Interviews: dos and don'ts

DOS	DON'TS
♦ Research the company. ♦ Prepare for tough questions. ♦ Greet interviewer enthusiastically. ♦ Focus on what you have to offer, not what you want. ♦ Know your rights as an interviewee. ♦ Have a positive attitude. ♦ Show confidence. ♦ Be professional. ♦ Follow up with a note or phone call.	♦ Don't discuss salary, benefit or vacation until an offer is made. ♦ Don't display personal habits, i.e. smoking, chewing gum, tapping pencil, stretching, juggling a foot ♦ Don't lie. ♦ Don't get too chatty about non-job topics. ♦ Don't blame others or disparage employees.